

Gut-wrenching miss: Arjun Babuta finished fourth in the men's air rifle final at the Paris Olympics, despite being in medal contention throughout. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Manu was second in the standings, with only Veronika Major of Hungary having bested her by equalling the Qualification Olympic Record (592).

Manu got off to a nervy start in the final, missing three of her first five shots on target. However, she bounced back to avoid getting eliminated until the eighth series, when she tied for third place with Major. The bronze-medal place eventually had to be decided via shoot-off, which saw Major register one extra hit (10.2-plus shots are considered hits) over Manu.

For a while, Manu stood transfixed at her firing point, refusing to believe what had just transpired. When the audience broke the deathly silence, applauding her for the creditable fourth-place finish, she switched her weapon into safety mode and returned to the seating area a few metres away from where the eventual medal ceremony would take place. Ironically, though, Manu was only a few millimetres away from that podium.

She is not the only shooter, though, to have missed the podium by the barest of margins. Arjun Babuta put up a brave fight against the likes of four-time Worlds medallist and world record holder Sheng Lihao and 2023 world champion Victor Lindgren. Still, he ended up losing the bronze medal to Croatia's Miran Maricic after giving in to the pressure and shooting a rare 9.5 off his final shot. Maricic was only 0.2 ahead of Babuta until the deciding shot was fired.

The curious case of the one missed target came back to haunt the Indian contingent once again, albeit this time in the shotgun arena. A surprise fourth-place finish from Anant Jeet Singh Naruka and Maheshwari Chauhan in the skeet mixed team qualification saw the duo lock horns with China in the bronze medal match. Jiang Yiting and Lyu Jianlin eventually won the

contest 44-43, with the latter registering a perfect series!

Like shotgun, 50m rifle 3 positions is an event not many would want to hedge their bets on. No Indian had ever made the final of the said discipline in the Olympics. Who would have known that a ticket collector from the little-known village of Kambalwadi in Maharashtra would not only finally break the jinx but also go on to medal in the category?

Swapnil Kusale ensured India finished its shooting campaign at Châteauroux with the highest number of medals from a single edition of the Olympics, bagging a bronze in the smallbore event.

Although he just managed to make the cut at seventh place during qualifying, he consistently fired at the 10-ring in 'Standing' in the final to ensure another medal for the country.

India, which had failed to open its account in Tokyo 2020, finished 14th on the shooting medal tally. Going purely by count, India will take fifth place, having won one medal more

than Great Britain, Guatemala and Switzerland.

China maintained its position from 2020, finishing top with 10 medals (five gold, two silver and three bronze). Meanwhile, South Korea (three gold, three silver) displaced the USA (one gold, three silver, one bronze) from the second spot.

The present, to be sure, is a happy place to be in, and celebrations should be in order, but one cannot help but think about the sheer number of frustrating 'what-could-have-beens'. While a number of Indian athletes are taking positive steps towards that one line beyond which glory awaits, the occasion tends to get big on a few who aren't able to get over it.

What if Manu had that extra hit? What if Babuta had shot a high-10? What if Sarabjot had made the final in the individual event? What if one of Maheshwari and Naruka had missed one less clay pigeon?

The questions are never-ending, but it is good to have one's sensibilities tickled for Los Angeles.

